

THE HOPEFULS Candidates coming out of a NEET-UG exam centre in Meerut, May 5

or answers, as unfair means. Offenders face up to 10 years in jail and a fine of Rs 1 crore. Harsher punishment has been prescribed in the case of organised paper leaks. The offences are cognisable, non-bailable and non-compoundable. They cannot be settled through compromise and the police can act without a warrant. This law will apply to most examinations conducted by the central government and its testing agencies. However, these laws don't guarantee an end to the paper leaks as action can be taken only after they have occurred.

HOW TO FIX THE MESS

As an immediate measure, most experts suggest adopting a CBT format to enhance security and plugging NEET's logistical vulnerabilities. Not that CBTs are free of glitches. The NTA postponed the National Common Entrance Test (NCET) this year, which was scheduled to be conducted on June 12, due to "technical issues". Hackers have attempted to compromise CBTs, as during the JEE-Mains in 2021. A tracking of the digital footprints eventually led to the arrest of the culprits. Newer technologies such as Artificial Intelligence (AI)-based proctoring, which is constantly improving, can mitigate the menace. Samyajit Mukherjee, an ethical hacker from the Indian School of Ethical Hacking, says that people charged with server safety need to be properly trained in digital security and its ever-evolving patterns. Every system must undergo Vulnerability Assessment and Penetration Testing every three months to determine its cyber security robustness.

Criticism of NEET has also focused on the pattern and difficulty level of the questions, which some argue are inconsistent and do not take into account the varied educational backgrounds of candidates. While the questions are primarily from NCERT textbooks, CBSE's AIPMT had more conceptual and image-based questions, while the current questions are more "match the following" type. This has enabled students to score higher marks, raising the cut-off.

A few experts advise learning from other countries like the US, which has standardised tests—SAT, ACT and GRE—for college and university-bound students, nearly four million of whom take these tests every year. These tests evaluate critical thinking rather than rote memorisation, which coaching centres help Indian students master through excessive practice. The government is thinking on similar lines, as Pradhan advocates a "flexible and less stressful exam system like the SAT".

However, unlike NEET, these are CBTs and held multiple times a year. SAT, for instance, can be taken seven times a year. Experts recommend the US model as it offers flexibility with multiple test dates throughout the year. It reduces stress by spreading the risk over an extended period rather than concentrating it on a single event. The Union education ministry had, in fact, in 2018 decided to hold NEET twice a year, but later shelved the idea.

The problem also goes beyond NEET and requires improving the quality of school education across India. A significant shift is needed from rote learning to an education system focused on inquiry and critical thinking, aligning with the objectives of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. For this, the government must implement extensive reforms in governance, curriculum and infrastructure. Also, allocate 6 per cent of the GDP to education, a desirable standard across the world.

Meanwhile, there's no escaping the fact that the NTA itself needs a major structural overhaul. It is essential to enhance the organisation's manpower by adding more domain experts and reduce dependence on outsourcing. Furthermore, faculty from top institutions should be involved in conceptualising and conducting various exams. Experts also recommend that the NTA be granted constitutional status, akin to that of the Union Public Service Commission or the Election Commission of India. The NTA interacts with various schools, colleges, universities and autonomous bodies across different boards, which are designated centres for conducting exams. But despite managing high-stakes competitive exams, these institutions are not accountable to the NTA. Giving it constitutional status would empower the agency to directly penalise affiliated schools that conduct the exams. Currently, the NTA is registered under the Societies Registration Act, 1860.

The ongoing controversy over NEET and NET has led to demands for ensuring the integrity and reliability of public examinations in India. Achieving this is challenging in a society and economy that has failed to provide adequate and equal opportunities that can meet the aspirations of its young people. This is what fosters an environment of unethical and criminal practices, and it is the responsibility of society as a whole to tackle the mess. ■

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